Corporación Astronómica Quilacán · Centro de Visitantes Quilacán

NIGHT ACCESS PERMIT CONDITIONS FOR TOUR OPERATORS, 2026–2027

Issued in La Serena on 15 September 2026 · Effective 1 October 2026 to 30 September 2027

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1. PURPOSE AND SCOPE

The Corporación Astronómica Quilacán operates the Centro de Visitantes Quilacán, a public observing centre on Cerro Quilacán at 1,140 m above sea level, reached by a private road that leaves Ruta D-41 at km 17.5 between La Serena and Vicuña. Any company, cooperative or independent guide that brings paying visitors to the Centre's night sessions in its own vehicle needs a Night Access Permit (Permiso de Acceso Nocturno, PAN). Hotel shuttles that only drop off guests holding individual tickets bought at the Centre's ticket office need no permit, but their drivers must follow Section 5. A permit covers one operator and one category and cannot be transferred.

Permit period 1 October 2026 to 30 September 2027

Issuing office Visitor Services Office, Calle Cordovez 586, Office 31, La Serena (Mon–Fri 09:00–14:00)

First allocation round Complete applications received by 15 October 2026

2. PERMIT CATEGORIES AND ANNUAL FEES

The annual fee is payable within 10 working days of the invoice and is not refunded if the operator stops trading. Fees include IVA at 19 %.

TABLE 1. PERMIT CATEGORIES, GROUP LIMITS AND ANNUAL FEES, 2026–2027

Cat.	Vehicle and group type	Max. visitors per session	Sessions per night	Annual fee (CLP)	Parking
A	Minibus, general tourism	15	2	640,000	P2
B	Coach, general tourism	30	1	1,240,000	P1
C	Van, independent guide	8	2	310,000	P2
D	School or university visit	40	1	95,000	P1
E	Astrophoto workshop	10	1 (Session 3 only)	480,000	P3 (dark)
F	Accessible tour	12	2	210,000	P2 ramp

Until 30 September 2026 the Category B fee was CLP 1,180,000 and there was no Category F; accessible tours were licensed as Category A. Category A permits issued for 2025–2026 to accessible tours may be converted to Category F free of charge until 31 October 2026.

Fictional document created for testing a question-answering system. All names, figures and organisations are invented.

3. SESSION TIMETABLE AND BOOKING

Every group must be booked by phone at least 48 hours ahead, stating the permit number, session, visitors by type (Table 3) and the responsible guide.

TABLE 2. NIGHT SESSIONS AND ARRIVAL LIMITS

Session	Start, Oct–Mar	Start, Apr–Sep	Duration (min)	Last arrival (min before)	Groups per session
0 – sunset terrace	20:15	18:15	60	20	3
1 – early sky	21:30	19:30	100	30	4
2 – deep sky	23:30	21:45	100	30	4
3 – astrophotography	01:00	00:00	180	45	2

Session 3 is open only to Category E permits. The Centre is closed on 24 and 31 December; the monthly calendar published on the 20th of the preceding month lists the open nights.

4. PER-VISITOR LEVY

The operator also pays a levy for every visitor admitted, invoiced monthly by the Finance Office. A bright night is one on which the Moon is at least 50 % illuminated and above the horizon at the session start, as marked in the monthly calendar; all other nights are dark nights.

TABLE 3. LEVY PER VISITOR AND SESSION (CLP, IVA INCLUDED)

Visitor type	Dark night	Bright night	Proof at the gate
Adult, 18 to 64 years	9,800	7,200	None
Young person, 6 to 17 years	5,400	4,100	ID card or passport
Child under 6 years	0	0	None
Senior, 65 years and over	6,900	5,200	ID card or passport
Student with university card	6,200	4,600	Valid student card
Resident of the Coquimbo Region	4,900	3,700	ID with regional address
Pupil on a Category D visit	2,500	2,500	Signed school list

Where a visitor fits more than one type, the lowest levy applies. Session 3 visitors pay the adult levy plus a CLP 3,500 dark-lot surcharge.

5. LIGHT AND VEHICLE DISCIPLINE ON THE ACCESS ROAD

The access road climbs 6.2 km from Ruta D-41 to the parking area. From 30 minutes after sunset:

1. From the km 3.0 marker (the cattle grid), dipped headlights only and a maximum speed of 30 km/h.
2. From the km 5.4 marker at the Portón Azul gate, parking lights only, maximum 15 km/h, following the marshal's red lantern to the assigned lot.
3. Engines off within 2 minutes of parking; no idling. Vehicles leave in convoy when released by the Night Safety Warden.

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4. Only red lamps on the terraces; no camera flash. Laser pointers are used only by the Centre's own guides.

6. WEATHER, CANCELLATION AND CREDITS

The Duty Astronomer on shift decides whether sessions go ahead, texting operators three hours before Session 1. Sessions are cancelled when forecast summit cloud cover exceeds 70 % or terrace wind exceeds 45 km/h. Coastal fog (camanchaca) below 900 m does not count as cloud cover.

If the Centre cancels, no levy is charged; a session interrupted by cloud within 40 minutes earns a 50 % levy credit. An operator cancelling less than 24 hours ahead pays 50 % of the levy; a no-show pays 100 % and is a minor breach.

7. RESPONSIBILITIES

Visitor Services Coordinator	Paulina Araya Cortés: issues permits and assigns session quotas.
Head of Night Operations	Dr Tomás Villalobos Pizarro: sets the Duty Astronomer roster.
Duty Astronomer (on shift)	Decides weather cancellations and may stop a session in progress.
Night Safety Warden (on shift)	Controls the access road and records breaches on form PAN-7.
Executive Director	Lorena Gaete Castillo: decides appeals against sanctions.

8. GUIDES AND INSURANCE

Every guide must hold the Centre's Dark-Sky Guide Induction certificate (6 hours, CLP 45,000 per guide, first Tuesday of each month, valid 2 years). Operators provide one certified guide per 15 visitors; a Category B coach always travels with two. Civil liability insurance of at least UF 3,000 per event is required.

9. BREACHES, SANCTIONS AND APPLICATION

TABLE 4. BREACH LEVELS AND SANCTIONS

Level	Examples	First occurrence	Repeat in season
Minor	White torch; up to 15 min late; no-show	Written warning	CLP 60,000 fine
Moderate	Headlights above Portón Azul; 1 to 3 visitors over limit	CLP 180,000 fine	14-day suspension
Serious	Uncertified guide; flash; over 3 visitors over limit	30-day suspension	Withdrawal for season
Very serious	Off-road driving; laser at an aircraft	Withdrawal	Barred next season

Appeals go in writing to the Executive Director within 10 working days of notification.

APPLICATION CHECKLIST

□ Form PAN-3 completed and signed by the operator's legal representative
□ Dark-Sky Guide Induction certificates for all guides named on the permit
□ Civil liability insurance policy of at least UF 3,000 per event

Operator's legal representative	Visitor Services Coordinator	Date received

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